Project: Worked examples
Title: Thermal expansion of a restrained bar
Status: DRAFT · Author: TempestOS (2026-10-23) · Checker: — (—) · Issued: —

1. Scope and method

A bar heated or cooled between two restraints: its free movement, the part closed by a gap before the restraint engages, the restraint force for a rigid or an elastic restraint, the axial stress that results and the movement that actually occurs, with the stress against an allowable.

WHAT IT CALCULATES	RELATION
Free expansion of the bar	$\delta_{free} = \alpha \cdot L \cdot \Delta T$
Expansion actually restrained, once any gap g has closed	$\delta_e = \text{sign}(\delta_{free}) \cdot \max(\lvert\delta_{free}\rvert - g, 0)$
Axial stiffness of the bar	$k_{bar} = E \cdot A / L$
Restraint force, from rigid supports or an elastic restraint k_s	$F = \delta_e \cdot k_{bar}$ (rigid); $F = \delta_e / (1/k_{bar} + 1/k_s)$ (elastic)
Thermal stress in the bar, compressive on heating	$\sigma = -F/A$
Net movement of the bar end	$\delta = \delta_{free} - F/k_{bar}$

Basis: Thermal stresses[1](Ch. 15); Thermal stresses and strains[2](§3-17).

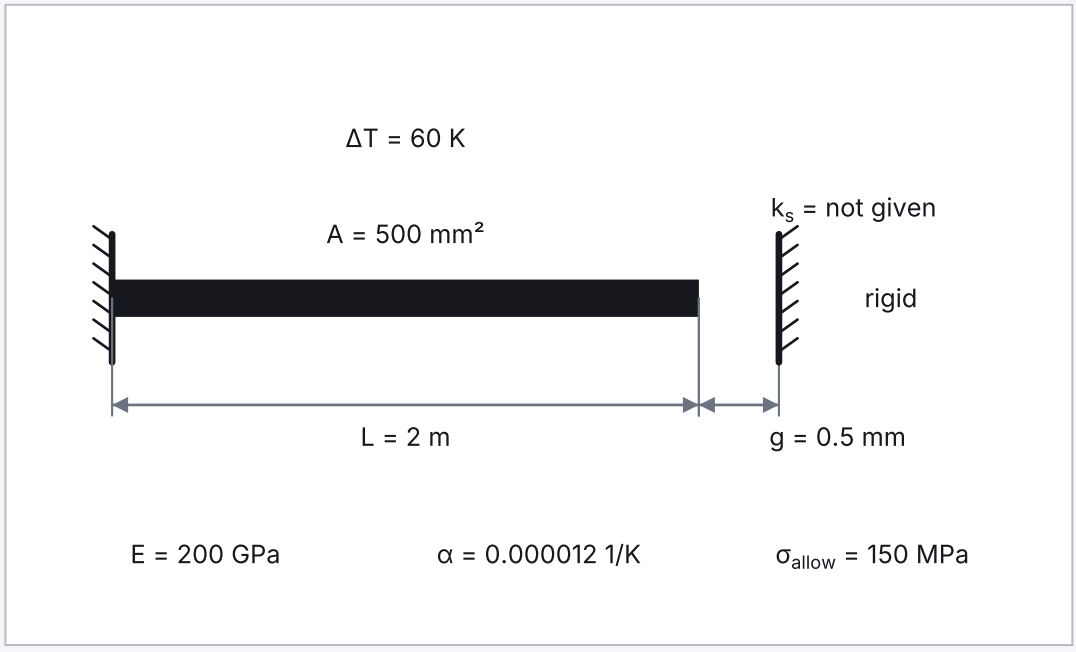


Figure 1 — A bar fixed at one end, a gap, then a rigid restraint (no stiffness given). Not to scale; the labels are the inputs as entered.

2. Inputs

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
L	Bar length	2	m	drawing: DRG-TX-501 rev A	0.01 … 1000 m

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
A	Cross-section area	500	mm²	drawing: DRG-TX-501 rev A	1 … 1000000 mm²
E	Modulus of elasticity	200	GPa	drawing: DRG-TX-501 rev A	1 … 500 GPa
α	Coefficient of thermal expansion	0.000012	1/K	drawing: DRG-TX-501 rev A	1e-7 … 0.0001 1/K
dT	Temperature change (positive heating)	60	K	spec: LOAD-SCHEDULE-01	-300 … 1000 K
g	Gap closed before the restraint engages	0.5	mm	drawing: DRG-TX-501 rev A	0 … 1000 mm
σ_{allow}	Allowable stress	150	MPa	spec: SPEC-MECH-03 design criteria	1 … 2000 MPa

3. Assumptions

A1. The expansion coefficient is constant over the temperature change and the bar stays elastic. (Linear thermoelasticity.)
A2. The bar is uniformly heated and does not buckle under the compressive force. (Check buckling separately (struct.column-buckling).)

4. Working

[8] $\delta_{free} = \alpha * L * dT$ [2](§3-17)
= 0.000012 1/K × 2 m × 60 K
= 1.44 mm
Free thermal movement (positive on heating)

[9] $\delta_e = \delta_{free} - g$
= 1.44 mm − 0.5 mm
= 0.94 mm
Movement after the gap closes (engaged movement)

[10] $k_{bar} = E * A / L$
= 200 GPa × 500 mm² / 2 m
= 50 kN/mm
Axial stiffness of the bar

[11] $F = \delta_e * k_{bar}$ [1](Ch. 15)
= 0.94 mm × 50 kN/mm
= 47000 N
Restraint force (rigid restraint)

[12] $\sigma = -F / A$
= −47000 N / 500 mm²
= -94 MPa
Axial stress (negative compressive)

[13] $\delta = \delta_{free} - F / k_{bar}$
= 1.44 mm − 47000 N / 50 kN/mm
= 0.5 mm
Actual movement

[14] $u = abs(\sigma) / \sigma_{allow}$
= abs(-94 MPa) / 150 MPa
= 0.62667
Stress utilisation

5. Results

SYMBOL	VALUE	DESCRIPTION
δ_{free}	1.4 mm	Free movement
δ_e	0.94 mm	Engaged movement
k_{bar}	50.00 kN/mm	Bar stiffness
F	47000 N	Restraint force
σ	-94.0 MPa	Axial stress
δ	0.50 mm	Actual movement
u	0.63	Stress utilisation (governing)

6. Checks (governing first)

RESULT	CHECK	DEMAND	CAPACITY	UTILISATION	REF
PASS	Thermal stress against allowable	u = 0.63	u ≤ 1	0.63	

7. Applicability

None.

8. Verification

Template mech.thermal-expansion@1.0.1 Content hash 07d40fe119d715ba Engine calc-engine/1.0.0
Known-answer cases passed 5/5 Test run 2026-10-23 12:00 UTC TempestOS 0.26.0

9. References

1. Young WC, Budynas RG, Sadegh AM. Roark's Formulas for Stress and Strain. 8th ed. McGraw-Hill; 2012.
2. Budynas RG, Nisbett JK. Shigley's Mechanical Engineering Design. 11th ed. McGraw-Hill Education; 2020.